

Honourable Speaker, respected adjudicators, and my dear opponents, a very good day to you all.

Today, this House believes that institutions should give more emphasis to life skills than theoretical skills.

We, on the Opposition bench, firmly disagree with this motion.

Our goal is very simple. We believe educational institutions should not merely produce people who are ready to enter existing jobs. They should also produce people who can create new knowledge, develop new ideas, build new businesses, and ultimately create employment opportunities for others.

Definitions

Life Skills

By life skills, we mean psychosocial abilities that allow individuals to deal effectively with the demands and challenges of everyday life.

Theoretical Skills

By theoretical skills, we mean abstract academic knowledge involving concepts, theories, and facts within a particular field.

Stakeholders

Students and Graduates: Direct beneficiaries of education.

Researchers and Academics: Develop and expand knowledge.

Entrepreneurs and Business Creators: Create businesses from knowledge and innovation.

Employers and Industries: Need qualified and specialized workers.

National Economy and Workforce: Benefit from innovation and employment.

Our Arguments

First Speaker: Institutions were created primarily for the systematic transmission of organized knowledge.

Second Speaker: Theoretical skills require greater care, time, resources, and structured guidance to develop.

Second Speaker: Employers value specialized theoretical and technical skills more directly when recruiting.

Third Speaker: Life skills can develop through everyday life, while advanced theoretical knowledge requires structured education.

Institutions were created primarily for the systematic transmission of organized knowledge.

Reasoning

An educational institution is not simply a place where people learn how to behave in society.

It is a structured environment where knowledge is collected, organized, taught, tested, and developed.

Students do not randomly learn subjects according to whatever happens in their daily lives. They follow a progression.

First they learn basic mathematics, then advanced mathematics.

They learn fundamental scientific principles, then specialized scientific concepts.

They move from introductory knowledge to professional expertise.

This systematic progression is exactly what makes institutions different from ordinary life.

Life skills are certainly important. Communication, decision-making, empathy, teamwork and problem-solving help people function better in society.

But these abilities are not the primary reason universities, colleges and other educational institutions exist.

The distinctive value of these institutions is that they allow society to systematically transfer accumulated knowledge.

And this becomes even more important when we think about the people who create new opportunities.

A future engineer needs engineering knowledge.

A future scientist needs scientific knowledge.

A future software developer needs computer science knowledge.

An entrepreneur developing a technological business may need years of specialized knowledge before that business can even exist.

Linking

Tu Youyou's achievement shows exactly why institutions must provide a structured environment for developing specialized theoretical knowledge. Her discovery of artemisinin did not come from life skills alone; it came from combining accumulated scientific knowledge, formal education, and systematic research.

This directly supports our assertion that educational institutions have a primary role in transmitting and developing organized knowledge.

And this matters to the motion because the question is not whether life skills are useful. They clearly are. The question is whether institutions should give them more emphasis than theoretical skills.

If we shift that emphasis away from systematic academic knowledge, we risk weakening the very foundation that produces researchers, innovators and professionals.

Therefore, because institutions are uniquely positioned to develop and advance specialized knowledge, theoretical skills deserve greater emphasis than life skills.

That is why our side rejects the motion.

My second speaker will explain why theoretical skills require more time, care, resources and structured guidance, and why employers require specialized theoretical and technical knowledge.

Thank you.

Honourable Speaker, respected Speaker and members of the House, thank you for giving me the floor.

The first speaker established that the fundamental strength of educational institutions is the systematic transmission of organized knowledge.

Our Arguments

Point One: Theoretical skills require greater care, time, resources, and structured guidance to develop.

Point Two: Employers value specialized theoretical and technical skills more directly when recruiting.

Theoretical skills require greater care, time, resources, and structured guidance to develop.

Reasoning

Theoretical knowledge does not appear overnight.

It is cumulative.

One concept depends upon another.

A student cannot suddenly understand advanced physics without first understanding basic physics and mathematics.

A person cannot become an engineer without learning the principles that engineering is based upon.

A doctor cannot become a doctor merely by learning how to communicate with patients.

They need years of organized scientific and medical education.

This requires teachers with subject expertise.

It requires structured curricula.

It requires textbooks, laboratories, academic resources, examinations and repeated practice.

Most importantly, it requires time.

And institutional time is limited.

Every hour used for one educational objective is an hour that cannot simultaneously be used for another objective.

Therefore, when the Government says institutions should give more emphasis to life skills, they have to recognize the opportunity cost.

Greater emphasis means greater classroom time, teacher attention, curriculum space and institutional resources being directed toward those activities.

Example

The construction of the **Golden Gate Bridge** is a real example of how advanced technical work required extensive theoretical knowledge, calculations, testing and specialized expertise. Charles A. Ellis directed thousands of calculations for the bridge design, while the engineers also relied on advances in suspension-bridge theory and tested a scale model to verify their calculations. The project therefore depended on sustained, specialized engineering knowledge rather than general life experience alone.

Linking

The Golden Gate Bridge demonstrates the reasoning very clearly. Such a complex structure could only be developed through extensive calculations, engineering theory, testing and specialized expertise.

So the example proves our assertion: theoretical skills require significant time, resources, expert guidance and structured learning.

And this directly relates to the motion. If institutions give substantially more emphasis to life skills, they must necessarily devote less time and institutional resources to developing the specialized knowledge required for complex work.

Therefore, because theoretical skills require greater investment and cannot simply be acquired through everyday experience, institutions should protect and emphasize them rather than reduce their importance.

Employers value specialized theoretical and technical skills more directly when recruiting.

Reasoning

Think about how companies actually recruit people.

When a company wants to hire an engineer, it needs someone who understands engineering.

When it hires a software developer, it needs someone who understands programming and computer systems.

When it hires a doctor, it requires medical knowledge.

When it hires an accountant, it requires accounting knowledge.

Communication and teamwork are useful in all of these professions.

But they do not qualify someone to perform the specialized task itself.

A person can communicate brilliantly and cooperate perfectly with others, but that does not make them a qualified surgeon, engineer or software developer.

Theoretical and technical knowledge provides the foundation upon which specialized work is performed.

Example

This is demonstrated by **Margaret Hamilton and NASA's Apollo program**. In 1965, Hamilton applied for and was hired to work on NASA's Apollo program because of her computer-science expertise. She later became the lead Apollo flight-software designer. During Apollo 11, software developed by her team helped the mission continue safely when the onboard computer was overloaded shortly before lunar landing. NASA recognized her scientific and technical contribution with an Exceptional Space Act Award.

Linking

Margaret Hamilton's work on Apollo 11 provides a real demonstration of why employers need specialized theoretical and technical knowledge. Her contribution was not based simply on communication or teamwork; it depended on advanced computing knowledge that allowed her team to develop software capable of handling a critical situation during the mission.

This supports our assertion that employers require people who possess the specialized knowledge needed to perform specialized work.

And this directly answers the motion. Educational institutions are responsible for preparing people for these professional roles. If they reduce emphasis on theoretical skills, they risk producing graduates who may communicate and cooperate well but lack the specialized knowledge required to perform the actual job.

Therefore, because specialized employment depends on specialized knowledge, theoretical skills deserve greater emphasis within educational institutions.

That is why the Government's position is insufficient and our side rejects the motion. Thank you.

Honourable Speaker, respected adjudicators, and members of the House, a very good day to you all.

The first speaker established that educational institutions were created primarily for the systematic transmission of organized knowledge.

The second speaker established that theoretical skills require greater time, care, resources and structured guidance, and that employers continue to require specialized theoretical and technical knowledge.

I will now present our final point and bring the entire Opposition case together.

Our Argument

Final Point: Life skills can develop through everyday life, while advanced theoretical knowledge requires structured education.

Life skills can develop through everyday life, while advanced theoretical knowledge requires structured institutional education.

Reasoning

Let us be clear.

We are not saying that theoretical knowledge can only be learned inside an institution.

That would be too absolute.

Our argument is that educational institutions provide the most systematic environment for acquiring advanced theoretical knowledge.

Consider the nature of life skills.

Communication develops when we communicate with parents, friends, teachers and colleagues.

Teamwork develops when we participate in sports, clubs, group activities and workplaces.

Decision-making develops through the choices we make every day.

Problem-solving develops when we face challenges in ordinary life.

In other words, these abilities can continue developing throughout a person's life and across many different environments.

Institutions can certainly strengthen them.

But institutions do not have a monopoly over them.

Theoretical knowledge is different.

Example

There are clear real-world examples of this difference.

Shinya Yamanaka studied medicine at Kobe University and later earned a PhD before carrying out the research that led to his Nobel Prize-winning discovery that mature cells can be reprogrammed into pluripotent cells. His breakthrough came through years of advanced scientific study and research.

Similarly, **William Conrad Röntgen's discovery of X-rays** came from specialized laboratory experimentation. In 1895, he investigated a mysterious glow produced during his experiments with cathode-ray tubes and spent weeks conducting further experiments to understand the phenomenon, eventually discovering X-rays.

These real discoveries demonstrate that advanced theoretical knowledge requires accumulated learning, systematic progression and specialized research.

Linking

The experiences of Shinya Yamanaka and Wilhelm Röntgen show the difference between skills that can develop through life and knowledge that requires systematic education and specialized study.

Communication, empathy and teamwork can be developed through ordinary human interaction and experience. But discoveries such as induced pluripotent stem cells and X-rays required accumulated scientific knowledge, advanced study, experimentation and structured research.

Therefore, the examples directly support our assertion that life skills can develop across many environments, while advanced theoretical skills require the structured environment that educational institutions provide.

And this is exactly why the motion should be rejected.

The question is not whether life skills matter. They do.

The question is which type of skill institutions should emphasize more. Since life skills can continue developing outside institutions, while advanced theoretical knowledge depends much more heavily on structured institutional education, institutions should place greater emphasis on theoretical skills.

Therefore, this final point strengthens the entire Opposition case and shows why this House must reject the motion.

Bringing the Opposition Case Together

First — Institutional Purpose: Our first speaker showed that educational institutions were created primarily for the systematic transmission of organized knowledge.

Second — Greater Difficulty: We established that theoretical knowledge requires more time, resources, expertise and structured progression to develop.

Third — Labour-Market Demand: We showed that employers recruiting for specialized occupations require theoretical and technical knowledge, because life skills alone cannot qualify someone to perform specialized professional work.

Fourth — Institutional Advantage: Finally, we showed that life skills can develop across everyday life and social experience, while institutions provide the systematic environment necessary for developing advanced theoretical knowledge.

And remember our goal.

We do not oppose life skills.

Of course communication matters.

Of course teamwork matters.

Of course decision-making matters.

But the question is not whether life skills are useful.

The question is:

Which should educational institutions emphasize more?

And our answer is theoretical skills.

Because our educational system should not merely produce people who are ready to find a place in the existing economy.

It should produce the scientists who discover.

The engineers who design.

The professionals who specialize.

The innovators who develop new solutions.

And the entrepreneurs who transform knowledge into businesses and employment.

A person with life skills may become a better participant in an existing system.

But a person with deep knowledge has the potential to understand that system, improve it, transform it, and create something entirely new.

So this debate is ultimately about what kind of future we want our institutions to build.

Do we want institutions that mainly prepare people to work within the world that already exists?

Or do we want institutions that equip people with the knowledge to create the world that comes next?

For our goal of producing not only job-ready workers, but also job creators, theoretical skills deserve greater emphasis.

For that reason, this House must reject the motion. Thank you.